NITISH'S SWOT TEST

STRENGTHS

- **Durable support among EBCs and women, built through targeted welfare and local outreach**
- **Reputation for steadiness and better law-and-order situation—a reassuring face in swing constituencies**
- **Essential alliance asset for the NDA; his presence consolidates votes across blocs**

WEAKNESSES

- **Age and fitness rumours dent perceptions of vigour**
- **JD(U)'s organisational reach shrinking; party no longer big brother to BJP**
- **Repeated alliance switches have bred opportunist image**

OPPORTUNITIES

- **NDA's combined vote share is also one that is transferable at party/assembly seat level**
- **Visible welfare measures (free electricity units, doles to women) are proof of delivery of social schemes**
- **No strong anti-incumbency against Nitish. The anger is of a more diffused variety**

THREATS

- **Tejashwi-led Opposition's youthful, job-centred pitch could mobilise first-time voters**
- **Alliance friction/ demoralised local cadre could erode ground mobilisation gains**
- **Promised jobs and investment slow to come; pre-poll dole offers may not materialise into votes**
- **Prashant Kishor could bag some of the anti-RJD and youth votes**

THE GREY SKIES LOOKED OMINOUS, but Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar was still on the road on November 1, addressing four election meetings on the day. One of them was in Jandaha in Mahnar constituency, Vaishali district, from where Umesh Kushwaha, the state president of his Janata Dal (United), is contesting.

Dressed in an immaculate white kurta, Nitish, 74, showed none of the portentous stiffness his opponents ascribe to the 'tired septuagenarian'. On the dais, he accepted garlands with an affable smile and took in the audience, a sea of female faces, with a smattering of old allies and earnest young men. "*Aap toh jaante hi hain* (You all know by now)," he begins, in a voice weathered by two decades in office and the many more running such campaigns. He soon gets down to it, listing the many works his government has done—the roads paved, the schools opened, electric poles erected across sleepy villages—summoning in the same breath the possibility that things could regress: the spectre of 'jungle raj' rising on the horizon. He called out the frictions that scarred the state under Lalu Yadav's rule back in the early noughties and then, with gentle insistence, asked not just for another term but for time: another chapter to complete the project he began two decades ago.

Having planted the seeds of doubt about the Opposition, Nitish turned to a theme that has come to define much of his political identity: women's empowerment. Reminders about reservations in police and government posts aside, it'll be the '*dashazari yojana*'—the Rs 10,000 Mukhya Mantri Mahila Rozgar scheme announced just before the election, money handed out to 12.1 million eligible women (one per household) to start small businesses—that should ensure the support of this relatively caste-neutral constituency.

As Nitish spoke, scores of women in the crowd raised their hands in approval; many were members of self-help groups, known as JEEViKA. Many are expecting it soon, but several have already received the money. They spoke of buying new clothes and Diwali sweets, of repaying part of a micro-loan—small transactions that, in the campaign's rhetoric, constitute the currency of "empowerment". Later on, JD(U) working president Sanjay Jha's brief speech stressed another point: "*Yeh paisa nahin lautana hai* (You don't have to return the money)". Meaning, it's all a bonanza.

The Nitish Calculus

Over the past two-and-a-half decades, Nitish has been CM nine times—propped up by the BJP on seven occasions and twice in alliance with the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD), now led by Lalu's son Tejashwi Yadav. Nitish now fronts the NDA once again against the brisk, young energy of Tejashwi's Mahagathbandhan (MGB). What explains Nitish's resilience? Well, among reason-